

Hari Om

Om Namo Bhagavate Vasudevaya ||

Om Sri Krishnaparamatmane Namah ||

Introduction

All philosophy and science stand for certitude through thinking. Logic and mathematics lay down the methods by which certitudes are reached, when mere thought, unsupported by methods or calculations, involves varying degrees of doubt about the steps of thinking or research.

Vedanta philosophy, or *brahmavidya* (Science of the Absolute) as it is more correctly named, is no exception to the rule. It seeks certitude about absolute Existence, Subsistence, or Value, compromised in one notion called Brahman. (Brahman should not be confused with Brahma, the four-headed god of the Hindu pantheon).

The Absolute, being by nature a mystery and a wonder, means that the teachings of Vedanta refers to a kind of philosophy that tends to be esoteric; but when it has been subjected to more critical, rational and intuitive treatment in the Bhagavad Gita, the subject matter attains to a fully philosophical status both from esoteric and exoteric norms of thought.

Methods of valid reasonings are employed in Vedanta to arrive at the finalized finds (or lakshya) of the Vedantic research or inquiry. These may be said to be answers to the two most generalized problems of all philosophical inquiry; two grand questions arising ever and everywhere in the human understanding — about one's own self and the world we see around.

Vedanta follows such wholesale lines of inquiry and boldly claims to hold the answer to these questions, which is more than the most intrepid of modern analytic philosophers dare to claim. Indians had no reason to divorce religion from philosophy to the extent Europeans had to due to the extremes and excesses of the dogmatism of the Middle Ages. The horrors of the Inquisition were a nightmare that haunted the conscience of the West, which can vie only with the cruelty and injustice of the caste system that has persisted in India. Both have tended to drive a wedge between aspects of spiritual life which, without them, should have belonged together as one discipline or expression of aspiration of Truth or Freedom. As a perennial philosophy, Vedanta tries to steer clear of historical and other considerations, and thus has a global, integral and unitively comprehensive character of its own.

Advaita Vedanta or more simply Advaita philosophy which is expressed through this sublime hymn of dialectics, when revalued and restated, can give us the norm and reference, both theoretical and practical, of a way of life and certitude that can claim a fully scientific status, while being a complete philosophy in its own right.

The Gita may be said to be the finest flowering of wisdom, pure or applied, which is sublime and precise at once. Its growing popularity through the centuries and even in modern times is sufficiently explained not so much by its cherished position among the religious textbooks of the Indian people in any closed or static sense, but because it highly deserves, by its universal appeal and by the high hope it holds out to all mankind, a permanent place among works referring to perennial and contemplative wisdom, which knows no barrier of race, religion or tradition.

Dialectics or Yoga as taught in the Gita

Throughout the Gita we are able to recognize a certain antique and somewhat outmoded yet time-honored type of reasoning known as Dialectics, which has close similarities to the method of Yoga as intended by the author of the Gita. Yoga and Dialectics have very much in common. When the dialectical character of the treatment of the Gita is understood, a door then opens automatically leading to the solution of many enigmas that have puzzled commentators throughout history. The yogic method of equating, balancing or cancelling out the counterparts belonging to an argument or a situation in life has a tradition dating back to antiquity in India and to pre-Socratic times in the West.

Each of the eighteen chapters of the Gita has been called a Yoga. Indeed, the very first chapter has the enigmatic title *The Yoga of the Conflict (Vishada) of Arjuna*. Conflict or suffering itself becomes elevated to the status of Yoga. It is not merely practical aspects of spiritual life or discipline that have been thus called Yoga, but even chapters devoted to theoretical problems of philosophy, such as Chapter XIII (The Yoga of the Distinction between the Actual and the Perceptual). It is only in the sense of Dialectics that such a term as Yoga in these titles has meaning.

The Gita uses a dialectical method to determine a scale of values in life, rather than teaching a particular doctrine. This series of values in the Gita culminates in that supreme Value called the Absolute or Brahman. The Gita is a textbook on the Science of the Absolute (*Brahma-Vidya*). Discursive reflection does not belong to the Gita, Rather it is a work of mysticism and intuitive penetration.

The supreme Value implied in the Gita teaching is attainment of identity with the Absolute, personified in the Guru here who happens to be Krishna. That the Guru and the Absolute are one is not a new proposition in Vedanta. Stress on devotion to a Guru cannot be considered a form of theism but is only normal to wisdom teaching in India. The Gita is meant by the author to teach one doctrine only. This teaching is that of a complete bipolar affiliation between the contemplative and the pure Absolute as one of the most important prerequisites for attaining to full wisdom of the Absolute.

The key to the proper appraisal of the Gita consists in the recognition of the Gita as a dialogue between a wise teacher and a disciple, a *Guru-sishya Samvada*. All wisdom teaching implies a representative questioner or a doubter who is sceptical of the doctrine propounded. Such a person typifies and sums up in himself the position in regard to the wisdom in question, and is known in Vedantic literature as the *purva-pakshin*. The Guru himself, who gives the revised, revalued or restated version of the wisdom in question, represents the *siddhantin*, one of finalized or accomplished views. Between the two poles represented by the Guru and the sishya, there takes place what we call the dialectical revaluation of the wisdom.

The core of the Gita therefore consists of a dialogue on the most secret aspects of Upanishadic wisdom. If the Upanishads are considered as original wisdom-texts or *Shrutis*, there is no reason to exclude the Gita from such a category of literature, when we know that Vyasa (the author) inserted this dialogue between Guru and Sishya in a larger epic poem, the Mahabharatha, for other reasons.

It should further be noticed that there is the use of the word *samvada* (dialogue). That this dialogue was not intended to be merely one between the charioteer Krishna and the warrior Arjuna is made sufficiently clear to the reader early in the second chapter, where Arjuna refers to himself as a sishya or disciple. The Guru is not so directly mentioned there, but only in another context in chapter XI, verse 43: "You are the supreme Guru"; but given the disciple, the teacher is to be understood. The situation demands him, by implication. Thus, although Krishna is successively a Charioteer, Friend, Adviser, Divine Person or Representative of the Absolute Principle, there is no violation of meaning to call him Guru over and above and inclusive of all other relationships.

He is not, however, a Guru like Bhishma or Drona, who are referred to as Gurus, but a Guru in a more absolute sense. He is called the Lord of Yoga (Yogeshvara), which is also not inconsistent with Guruhood. Krishna refers to himself as representing the Absolute in its different aspects in chapter XIV, verse 3 "My womb is great Brahma — supreme Deity" and XIV, 27 "For I am the basis of the Absolute and the unexpended nectar of immortality, and the eternal way of right conduct, and of lonely final happiness," and in many other places.

These indications are more than sufficient to justify our taking the greater portion of the work. If the Gita is compared to a lotus flower (it is called *Bharata Pankajam*, "Lotus of the Bharata"), such a lotus would have many protective petals covering its heart. The core of the lotus with its fragrance would represent the dialogue portion set down by the son of Parasara (Vyasa) which contains the wisdom of the Absolute stated as revealing itself to the supreme Sun. Protecting such a precious teaching are the outer features that accompany the teaching only indirectly, and which refer to the epic's war situation. These latter have to be treated as incidental to the Gita, although not to be treated as having nothing to do with the rest or as being totally extraneous to the subject matter. It shows that wisdom and spiritual values of life can be applied at any field of action, unlike other texts which employ a similar dialectical method of wisdom teaching like the Upanishads, where the setting is located in the modest hut of the teacher deep in the silent

valleys of the Himalayas. Here the author brings the Guru-Sishya samvada amidst a communal war which can be imagined as the ugliest of all situations possible in human life, that shows how spiritual values and the wisdom of the absolute is all inclusive.

A Garland of Values

The Neo-Platonic philosopher Plotinus employed this method of dialectics almost as in the Gita, unitively bringing together matter and spirit. In modern times Bergson also understood and employed dialectics in developing his metaphysical ideas. Thus we would be in good company still when we say that dialectics is a secret time-honored way of perennial mysticism or philosophy which is based on intuition rather than reason. It yields unitive results consisting of values in life ranging from the most commonplace to the highest.

All values in life could be strung by dialectics into a garland of human values, each precious in its own context. The eighteen chapters of the Gita string together different values in life through its own notion of the Absolute — the Absolute being the correlating principle as mentioned in VII,7:

“In Me all this is strung as a classified series (ganah) of precious beads on a string.”

A sample of the dialectical method of reasoning is given by Vyasa in that symmetrically balanced verse II, 16:

“What is unreal cannot have being and non-being cannot be real: the conclusion in regard to both of these has been known to philosophers/seers.”

This method and the three definitions of yoga in the following verses taken together are meant to explain what the word yoga means in Gita:

“Engage in activity, O Dhananjaya (Arjuna), taking your stand on the unitive way (of yoga) discarding attachments and capable of regarding both attainment as the same: in sameness consists the unitive way (of yoga)”. II, 48.

“Affiliated to reason one leaves behind here both meritorious and unmeritorious deeds. Therefore affiliate yourself to the unitive way (of yoga): yoga is dexterity in action”. II, 50.

“That should be known by the name of yoga — disaffiliation from the context of suffering. Such a yoga should be adhered to with determination, free from spiritual regret”. VI, 23.

Yoga refers to the Absolute and yields unitive interests in every department of life. It implies detachment from the outside world of sense activity.

When we examine the structure of individual verses, we find this same method of juxtaposing counterparts and equalizing them is strikingly employed. We have already referred to the example in II, 16 which states the case of dialectics in as clear a manner as possible: "What is unreal cannot have being and non-being cannot be real: the conclusion in regard to both of these has been known to philosophers/seers."

Here we have two propositions stated together, one being the counterpart of the other. This is not a type of reasoning which is strictly syllogistic. There is no middle term and the principle of contradiction is not availed of, nor that of an excluded middle. If we try to place this form of argument in the context of the *Tarka Shastra* (Textbook on Logical Reasoning Method) of Annam Bhatta of the Nyaya-Vaisesika school, we find that instead of *abhava* (non-being) postulated by them, we have here a vague middle-term entity, which is admitted and put forward by implication as possible. None of the dualistic schools could be meant here by the reference to philosophers. This way of reasoning has its background in the Upanishads and the Vedas themselves. To cite but one instance, we have the famous reference to *vidya* (science) and *avidya* (nescience) which are taken up in the Isha Upanishad for dialectical treatment side by side with the parallel example of the two concepts of *sambhuti* (becoming) and *vinasha* (extinction). There is reference to ancient philosophers even there who were capable of treating these two counterparts together, as implied in the expression *ubhayam-saha* (bearing both) used there. The expression *ubhayam* (both) is characteristic of this rare type of philosophical reasoning employed also in Gita.

Let us take another example, XVIII, 12, from the Gita, which shows the special character of this kind of argument:

"Pleasant, unpleasant and mixed benefits accrue in the spiritual progress beyond of the non-relinquisher (*atyagi*) but none anywhere for the renouncers (*samnyasis*)".

Here the question involved is one of comparing the renouncer (*samnyasi*) with the relinquisher (*tyagi*). But instead of more simply and directly accomplishing this task by taking a relinquisher and a renouncer, both of whom have points of similarity, this verse takes the non-relinquisher and compares him with a renouncer. The *atyagi* has nothing in common with the *samnyasi*, but there is a common ground to the imperfect, humanly conceivable *samnyasi* and a *tyagi* who is quite advanced in spirituality. So by opposing the full *samnyasi* and the non-*tyagi*, we arrive at a conclusion where the *samnyasi* and the *tyagi* have a common ground wherein one is as good as the other. The method implied here may be said to be that of DIALECTICAL REVALUATION of both renunciation (*samnyasa*) and relinquishment (*tyaga*) in the light of the neutral Absolute. The middle way common to both the *tyagi* and the *samnyasi* is the path recommended by the Gita.

In IV, 18 we have another striking example of the use of subtle dialectics in the Gita, (this type is representative of others, such as II, 69 and VI, 6) as an interesting sample:

“One who is able to see inaction in action and action in inaction, he among men is intelligent; he is the one of unitive way (yogi) while still engaged in every (possible) kind of work”.

The relation between action (*karma*) and inaction (*akarma*) here cannot be one of complete mutual exclusion with any middle ground between them. There is a possibility implied that action and inaction could exist neutrally in one and the same person. For examples we should have to turn to the paradoxes of Zeno, the pupil of Parmenides. Very clever commentaries have been lavished by intelligent thinkers on the possible meaning of these contradictory requirements. Some explain it dualistically; others insist on giving a strictly non-dualistic meaning.

The neutral Absolute is attainable only to a certain rare type of reasoning sometimes called intuition and at other times direct awareness. Sankara refers to this faculty by the term *uha-poha*, a double way of thinking where there is a forward and backward movement employed in arriving at certitude. When the methods of comparison and contrast are employed together in a certain organic way, that would correspond to what this way of reasoning represents. Apparent paradoxes give up their intrinsic verity and are solved by the same intuitive method. The term nearest to this type of reasoning is “dialectics”, which we have already explained.

A dialectical revaluation of contemplation

Wrong or imperfect beliefs in the domain of spiritual life have prevailed because of ignorance in regard to the fully Absolutist way of wisdom. In this matter, the Gita undertakes a thoroughgoing dialectical revaluation of contemplative spirituality under the name of yoga.

The anterior wrong opinions which are subjected in the Gita to such a process of revaluation so as to yield the teaching of the Gita in its finalized form may be discussed conveniently under the following categories: (1) The path of the Ancestors (*pitriyana*) and the Path of the shining Gods (*devayana*); (2) The Rational and Pragmatic Approach (*samkhya*) and the Approach of Self-Discipline (Yoga); (3) Sacrifices, Austerities and Offerings; and (4) Renunciation (*Samnyasa*).

Pitriyana and Devayana: Pitriyana is the path of the ancestors. This is a widely prevailing form of religious or spiritual life not only of India but of the whole world. Before the Aryans, who brought the Vedic sacrifices with them which referred to the shining gods (devas) such as Indra and Varuna, the vast matrix of Indians had ancestral forms of worship. Arjuna himself is somewhat representative of this ancestral formation, although he may have been familiar with Vedic worship too through his preceptor Drona. Both pitriyana and devayana are revalued in the Gita in various chapters. The characteristic silence of Krishna that we have noticed, to the philosophical and religious scruples of Arjuna, in the first chapter, shows that both the ancestral way and the way of the gods are meant to be replaced by the thoroughgoing Absolutist way.

This revalued way includes both of the old ways as flooded area can hide an old well — to use an analogy employed in Gita itself in II, 46.

“There would be as much use for all the Vedas to a brahmana of wisdom as there could be for a pool of water when full flood prevails all over”.

This is the first case of revaluation which Gita student has to keep in mind.

Samkya-Yoga: The revaluation of Samkhya and Yoga is mentioned with telling emphasis in V, 4 and 5:

“That rationalism (Samkhya) and unitive self-discipline (Yoga) are distinct, only children say, not the well-informed (panditah); one well established in any one of them obtains the result of both”.

“That status attained by men of rationalist persuasion (Samkhya) is reached also by those of unitive self-discipline (Yoga); rationalism (Samkhya) and Self-discipline (Yoga) as one, he who sees thus, he (alone) sees”.

This revaluation however, has other implications. The rejection of ritualistic Vedism has already been accomplished in II, 44:

“In the case of those whose minds are under the sway of such teachings, who are attached to enjoyment and domination, a well-founded reason does not come under the sway of the peace of contemplation (samadhi)”

The cutting ruthlessly of the mystical tree of Chapter XV also involves the rejection of relativist Vedism in favour of an Absolutism which still includes whatever is most precious in the Vedic pattern of Spirituality. Reason and ritual are not estranged in the Gita teaching, but are brought unitively together under the aegis of the Absolute, as implied in IV, 24:

“(For him) the Absolute (Brahman) is the act of offering, the Absolute is the substance offered into the Absolute which is the fire offered by (him) the Absolute, the end to be reached by him being even the Absolute by means of his peace supreme of Absolutist action”.

Sacrifice, Austerity and Offering: Contemplative life which expresses itself through these three channels has also been subjected to revaluation in the Gita, and this is unequivocally stated in VIII, 28:

“Whatever meritorious result is found implied in the Vedas, in sacrifices, austerities and offerings (gifts), the contemplative who is unitively established, having understood this (teaching here) transcends all these and attains to the supreme primal State”.

While the task has been more completely accomplished in Chapter XVII, e.g. verses 27 and 28:

“Steady loyalty in sacrifice, austerity and giving (offerings) is also called SAT (good and existing) and also action so intended is called SAT.”

“Whatever is sacrificed, given or done, and whatever austerity is gone through, without faith it is called ASAT (non-existent, no-good), O Partha (Arjuna); it has no value here or hereafter”.

Samnyasa: The dialectical revaluation of *samnyasa* or renunciation is perhaps one of the most important original contributions of the Gita. From the point where Arjuna refers to taking to a life of begging, up to the last chapter where the whole question is subjected to a very close dialectical scrutiny and revaluation, the Gita has many references giving truer picture of what the perfected *samnyasi* (renunciator) ought to present. The perfected renunciator who can really abstain from activity is portrayed in XVIII, 49:

“He whose reason is unattached in situations, whose Self has been won over, from whom desire has gone, by renunciation (*samnyasa*) he reaches the supreme perfection transcending action”.

Such a task of dialectical revaluation, however, involves a progression in the arguments proceeding from stage to stage. The eighteen chapters of the Gita thus forms different steps, cross sections, or distinct frames of reference, and between each of them there will be differences of angle of vision which many may tend to treat as contradictory statements. Viewed in the light of a sweeping, generously conceived and comprehensive dialectical revaluation of the whole range of spirituality, and taking representative sections for convenience only, the apparent contradictions, which might appear glaring at first sight, become perfectly compatible with the general teaching of the Gita.

Even those who hold the Gita in great respect have directly or indirectly contributed to degrading this noble masterpiece of contemplative science, having such rare unity of structure and revealing such attention to detail and correctness of critical expression, by looking upon it as a work which gives whatever answer is sought from it by anybody.

The Gita is not a book of good luck, nor an encyclopaedia, nor is it one whose philosophy is lacking in organic unity. It is true that a vast range of subjects has been touched upon by the author. Merging the self in the Absolute Self finds mention side by side with dietetic questions, or gazing at the tip of the nose or offering a fruit or a flower to God. In the light of the structure of the Gita as we have explained above, and in the peculiarities of the treatment as a dialectical revaluation of anterior spiritual notions, it will be readily conceded that the charges of being eclectic, syncretic and even solipsist, would not apply to the work.

The perfection of the structure of Gita, when examined in detail, would also refute the possibility of interpolations in the text, by which, according to many scholars, it is marred. The truth is that the Gita has not been subjected to serious study in the same sense that, Shakespeare has been studied. This has been its misfortune. As a result, political and religious adventurers have taken advantage of the Gita to support their own favourite doctrines.

The Gita is a wisdom dialogue of a non-religious and non-obligatory, contemplative and philosophical order, consciously and artfully inserted in the heart of the great epic called the Mahabharata by the ancient Sage-Bard Vyasa; in which the rarest of possible coincidences called absolutely just war is taken as presenting itself to be fought by its central character, Arjuna, who, being a sensitive and contemplatively disposed type of soldier, is about to adopt a negative, escapist attitude of regret and retrospection when it was actually too late for him to extricate himself from the situation that had already assumed a harsh and imperatively necessary character. Arjuna suffered from self-pity, regret or mystical agony, blurred his outlook, making him claim prematurely the high virtue of renunciation while still given to relativist patterns of thinking altogether incompatible with the thoroughly absolutist philosophy and way of life that the Gita brings out through the words of Krishna as representing the Guru and Absolute at once. Krishna, who, besides being the Guru, is also relation, friend and charioteer of Arjuna, takes every possible measure at every possible level of life, to remove the philosophical doubts, religious scruples and psychophysical inhibitions which dimmed Arjuna's vision and clogged his spirit. Eloquently and in elevating language, Krishna preaches that rare type of unitive wisdom or Absolutist way of life known as Yoga, a mystical and intuitive path of contemplative dialectics. Established in this unitive way by which inner and outer factors of life are equalized, harmonized or neutralized, Arjuna is able to get rid of superstitious repressions and conflicts. He regains normality of outlook as a true yogi who does not particularly wish to avoid war when it is absolutely necessary, just and conducive to general happiness. Whether he adopted the way of quiet contemplative retirement portrayed in the last chapter or whether he engaged in harsh warfare is left an open question by Vyasa. Before the epic moves onward in its grand heroic pace again, we find Arjuna a fully disillusioned contemplative ready to affiliate himself wholeheartedly as one of the counterparts of a contemplative situation in which Krishna himself is involved as representing the supremely Absolute Value.

Chapter 1: The Dialectical Conflict of Arjuna

No culture in the world had ever harnessed so successfully the scintillating possibilities of drama in literature for philosophical exposition as the ancient Hindus. The highest and the best in Hindu philosophy have been reiterated in a more elaborate and detailed dramatic layout protolinguistically amidst the din and roar of total war. Sri Krishna gives out his message of acting with one's courage of conviction amidst any situation that life may bring.

This chapter deserves to be treated on par with the rest of the chapters dealing with the Science of the Absolute. Before anything subtle or profound can be taught, the *purvapaksha* or the anterior position of the skeptic regarding such teaching has to be determined with clarity. This chapter, therefore, can be said to contain the key to a proper understanding of the teaching in the rest of the book.

Arjuna who is pictured as a great Hero does not turn into a mere coward on the battlefield. His confusion is of a representative character, one in which the cause of his grief of dejection is the very fact that he has to fight a communal war with his brethren. *Drtharashtra* who is the father of the Kauravas is also seen shattered and disappointed once Sanjaya returns on the 10th day of battle and shares the horrific images of war and the sad fate of his children. This chapter's dialectical character is self-evident from the very first verse of Gita itself, despite knowing what has happened to his children, *Drtharashtra* asks *Sanjaya* about what the Pandavas did and what happened to his children and the rest of the kaurava forces.

Sloka 1:

dhṛitarāśhtra uvācha:

**dharma-kṣhetre kuru-kṣhetre samavetā yuyutsavaḥ
māmakāḥ pāṇḍavāśhchaiva kimakurvata sañjaya**

Dhritarashtra said: In the righteousness-field, the field of Kurus, gathered together, intent on the battle, what did my people and also the sons of Pandu do? O Sanjaya?

In Sanskrit works, it is a recognized tradition that the opening stanza should generally indicate the whole of the text. In this way, when we consider the *Gita*, we find that this Song Divine starts with the word “Dharma” and concludes with the term Mine (Mama); and therefore the contents of the Gita - we may conclude - are nothing but ‘My Dharma’ (Mama Dharma). The blind king after listening to the heartbreaking stories from Sanjaya asks thus, which is indicative of the fact that the verse is much more than what it literally means. Sage-bard Vyasa intends to give the reader the thrill of philosophical reflection.

Drtharashtra is portrayed as a blind king for various reasons; one central theme of this character is that he is blind to righteousness and an intelligent and harmonious way of Life. This is seen in the Mahabharata, Sage Vyasa visits his son Drtharashtra and offers him the “sight” to see and know everything that'll be taking place in the great war. Drtharashtra refuses both offers, which shows the human tendency to hold on to their ignorant way of thinking, no matter how much pain or fear it gives us.

The blind king said to his father (Vyasa):

‘Yatha bhavaan vethi thadhasmi vetha

***Bhavabhavo may vidhitho yathartho
Swarthe he sammyuhathi thatha lokah:
Maam chaapi lokathmakameva vidhi'***

*O Father, I know what is righteous and what is not,
just like you do
But the world seems to be immersed in selfish actions,
So I follow them as one among them.*

It is important to understand the meaning of the term “Dhritarashtra” before we proceed.

‘Drtham-rashtram yena sa: drtharashtra:’

He who blindly holds on to an idea, person or possession is the literal meaning. Thus *Gita* addresses a majority population in our world and not just a fictional character in the great epic. A common man working towards his selfish goals rejecting every other aspect of his society - moral, ethical or philosophical can be a perfect picture of drtharashtra if we expand our vision outside of this work and observe the world.

The term Dharma, which is usually translated as ‘righteousness’ or ‘piety’ needs a dialectical revaluation in such a situation. The very term is rendered more clear when it is explained thus

‘Dharyate iti Dharma’

‘That (on wearing) which makes a thing itself’

E.g.: It is the Dharma of the Sun to illumine

Therefore, Being humane, righteous, and non-threatening becomes the right way of life (Dharma) and the very contrary being selfishness and evil becomes Adharma. This reveals the fully contemplative character of the first chapter. Looking at Drtharashtra, being one of the four children of Sage Vyasa - it is a natural doubt of any contemplative student that how can such a man be born to a great Sage, to answer this we must dive into the details of the great epic itself. After Vichitravirya's death, his mother Satyawati sent for her first born, Rishi Veda Vyasa. She asked him to father children on the widowed queens of Vichitravirya according to the prevalent custom of Niyoga (a book of laws). Amba and Ambalika held a tremendous grudge towards the kingdom after they were forced to marry Vichitravirya against their will. When Vyasa approached Ambika, she closed her eyes in disgust and rejection, As a result, the blind Dhritrashtra was born. When he approached Ambalika, she turned pale in fear. Her son Pandu, was born

with a pale appearance. The third child Vidura was conceived through a dasi (servant) who fully accepted the plight, and it is shown evidently that the third son Vidura was a man of wisdom and inherited all good qualities from his father (Vyasa).

We see here that Dritharashtra is desperately asking for justification about the failure in his life. The Kauravas who were 101 in number represents the evil forces which work in everyone's bosom, whereas the Pandavas being five in number represents the noble and divine qualities. In conclusion, the first verse should be asked by everyone who intends on a revaluation of their lives at any age, after they become aware of this subjective warfare. This is the first step towards the way to wisdom and intelligent living. Note that the literary device of employing Drtharashtra speaking to Sanjaya belongs to the front curtain. He is the "holder of the kingdom" who is to decide whether he is to maintain the status quo or let things happen or shape themselves according to truth or justice. He refuses to allow any revaluation or readjustment to take place. To that extent, he is a blind statesman. His party, led by Duryodhana, are also to be considered diehards who will not let the old order of change to give place to the new.

Krishna's way of thinking or his spirituality has its greatest obstruction in Duryodhana [Duryo-dhana - he who misuses wealth and power], who goes to heaven in the end, but heaven is not the ideal of the absolutist spirituality of Krishna. The Gita stands for pure Absolutism -- i.e., for no benefits or fruits of action, whether here or hereafter, thus conforming to the requirements tacitly understood within the discipline of the Vedanta. The reader has to be clear in his mind about the nature of the contending parties, so that in the context of righteousness, he can determine which side here deserves his support -- otherwise even as a Purana or legend the Gita loses its point, and it will fail to make him any wiser than he was before he read it. Hence these indications, though seemingly elaborate, becomes necessary.

The blind king is asking Sanjaya about what happened to his children and what did Pandavas do in the Kurukshetra battlefield. Note the character Sanjaya, who represents a mind which is well versed in the scriptural knowledge as well as reflecting upon the knowledge he gained from his teachers. Such a mind is rendered introspective in search of truth, rather than turned outwards in search of perfect peace and happiness in the world (materialism). This theme is also reflected in Ramayana where Ravana, who is also called desa-mugha (having ten heads) is the arch-enemy of Rama (representing knowledge and right values of life). Upon more reflection, it can be seen that the whole *Gita* is structured so that every character represents some aspect of the human personality. It is a journey between Drtharashtra and Sri Krishna via Sanjaya and

Arjuna. The full potential of subjective self-unfoldment is thus beautifully expressed through this timeless song.

Sloka 2:

sañjaya uvācha:

**dr̥iṣṭvā tu pāṇḍavānīkaṁ vyūḍhaṁ duryodhanastadā
āchāryamupasaṅgamyā rājā vachanamabravīt**

Sanjay said: On observing the Pandava army standing in military formation, King Duryodhana approached his teacher Dronacharya, and said the following words.

Sanjaya is seen to answer Drtharashtra's question, the fact that Duryodhana's name itself signifies "difficult to fight" indicates the conservative diehard. He is, therefore, the active agent of Drtharashtra, who is himself not very active or is debarred by blindness from the action. Drtharashtra being blind to the Truth, and in his talk to Sanjaya is theoretically interested in what is happening. This is indicative of a man stepping away from the dark-pit of egoism and false knowledge and begins to introspect and dialectically reevaluate his own life. Thus these characters in Gita completes the picture and the Darwinian theory of evolution, which ends at the man as the supreme most creature. He who cannot put forth the necessary efforts to bring knowledge into practicality asks this question to Sanjaya which indicates the path of knowledge or the student of contemplation or a seeker of knowledge and then proceeds to Nara-Narayana samvaada (dialectics between Arjuna and Krishna), which are the final steps to wisdom.

Thus, we need not persecute ourselves for having an attachment, desire, bad habits or ignorance. These are considered as eligibility for he who yearns for the Supreme Knowledge, Truth and Bliss that follows both. As a child would run to its parents in fright, so too, Duryodhana, unsettled in his mind, runs to his teachers. This weakness arising from his wrong motives, unjust cause, however well equipped he is in war shows the mental condition of all tyrants and lusty dictators. The Kauravas had a total of 11 akshauhini (battle formations), and they had to face Pandavas who had 7 akshauhinis. Subjectively they indicate the mental formation or temperament in each individual. The 11 akshauhini are indicating the 5 organs of perception and 5 organs of action divorced from each other and the confused mind which is run by its own desires and impulses (5+5+1), on the other hand the 7 akshauhinis is a picture of an integrated personality where the organs of action and perception acts in harmonious union under the mind which is under the intelligent discipline of the Intellect (5+1+1).

Gita as it can be interpreted and approached in many ways, i.e., historically, linguistically, devotionally, but they make the student go astray in search of details that are insignificant or even deceiving. The author of Gita wants it to be understood dialectically, the subtle philosophy of the Upanishads is expressing through different kinds of characters (good, bad, and indifferent - representing the personality in Man). Duryodhana having approached his teachers, there are three who enjoys the rank of spiritual teachers or acharyas, on the side of the Kauravas, namely Drona, Bhishma, and Kripa. The last is related to Drona himself as brother-in-law, and both probably belong to the Vedic context. On the other hand, Bhishma is a *Brahmachari* (student of the science of absolute) or a strict bachelor who is a patriarch (pitamaha) rather than a priest. His virtues are many, including continence, wisdom, bravery, fidelity to his word, etc. He is a model of spirituality equally important beside Drona and given equal status in the Gita Dhyana, where these two are considered as constituting the two banks of the battle-river, which is the river of dialectical revaluation of spirituality in terms of the absolutism of Krishna Paramatma, who is mentioned as the ferryman who is capable of taking the devotees across the stream of rapids, whirlpools, rocks, crocodiles and billows - representing the various impediments in the relativist world (samsara). The absolutist standpoint represents the boat wherein the Guru (Krishna Paramatma) is the Ferryman.

On the Pandava side, therefore, there is one Guru and one only: Krishna, who teaches *Brahmavidya*, the Science of the Absolute, as against many partial gurus and numerous followers of different kinds on the side of the Kauravas. This is also indicative of when the students realize his Guru as the Paramatman (Supreme Self) rather than a mortal teacher, who is but a seeker more advanced.

Sloka 3:

paśhyaitāṁ pāṇḍu-putrāṇām āchārya mahatīṁ chamūm

vyūḍhāṁ drupada-putreṇa tava śhiṣhyeṇa dhīmatā

Behold! O, Teacher! The mighty army of the sons of Pandu arrayed by the son of Drupada, thy wise disciple.

The son of Drupada is Dhristadyumna. He is considered as the archenemy of Kauravas, which is fairly clear from the fact that he was later killed at the hands of Ashvathaman, the son of Drona – although Drona was his teacher. Note how pointed reference is made to Dhristadyumna, son of Drupada, as a disciple of Drona, although the

Pandavas have been tutored in archery by Drona, including more important disciples like Arjuna and Dharmaputra, who are omitted. The reason for the omission is probably that the latter represent righteousness in keeping with the absolutist teaching of Krishna, and so they are less capable of actual rancor, which is a desirable quality on the battlefield.

It is indeed stupid of Duryodhana to point out to Drona the army formation of Pandavas, Later on, also, we shall find Duryodhana talking too much, and that is a perfect symptom indicating the inward fears of the great king over the outcome of the unjust war.

Sloka 4-6

**atra śhūrā maheṣhvāsā bhīmārjuna-samā yudhi
yuyudhāno virāṭaśhcha drupadaśhcha mahā-rathāḥ**

**dhṛiṣṭaketuśhchekitānaḥ kāśhirājaśhcha vīryavān
purujit kuntibhojaśhcha śhaibyaśhcha nara-puṅgavaḥ**

**yudhāmanyuśhcha vikrānta uttamaujāśhcha vīryavān
saubhadro draupadeyāśhcha sarva eva mahā-rathāḥ**

4. Here are heroes, mighty archers, equal in battle to Bhima and Arjuna, Yuyudhana, Virata and Drupada, each commanding eleven-thousand archers.

5. Dhrishtaketu, Chekitana and the valiant king of Kashi, Purujit and Kuntibhoja and Saibya, the best of men

6. The strong Yudhamanyu and the brave Uttamaejas, the son of Subhadra and the sons of Draupadi, all of them, divisional commanders.

We have a list of names of all those who were noted personalities in the Pandava army. Duryodhana, reviewing his enemies standing in formation, recognizes very many noted men of war functioning as *Maharathas* in the Pandava forces.

Bhima: Yudhishthira's Commander-in-Chief, elder brother of Arjuna.

Arjuna: Pandava hero, a central figure in the Gita and representative skeptic or Purva pakshin.

Yuyudhana (also called Satyaki): Krishna's charioteer when the latter is playing the usual part of a warrior in the epic.

Virata: a prince who sheltered the Pandavas

Drupada: Father of Draupadi, wife of the Pandavas.

Drishtaketu: King of the Chedis.

Chekitana: Warrior in the Pandava army.

Kasi-Raja: King of Benares.

Purujit: A king and brother of Kuntibhoja.

Kuntibhoja: A king

Saibya: King of Shibus.

Yudhamanyu: A warrior

Uttamaujas: One of great valor.

Subhadra: Son of Arjuna and his wife Subhadra.

Draupdeya: Of the line of Drupada.

Besides the names of important persons, epithets will occur throughout the Gita. They should not be mixed up with the clear spiritual message of the Gita. The teaching must be filtered out free from all such incidental dross belonging to the epic. An epithet like *maharatha*, which literally means one having a great chariot which denotes some military rank, like that of a field marshal, when dialectically revaluated means one who is able to hold his mind and intellect's equipoise with no regard as to how many external stimuli is arriving (some of them capable of disturbing the mind).

The name Drupada means he who is unshakable, he has his guidon symbol a tree which represents the value of Truth. Thus, it indicates that the Pandavas are much more powerful in war and this is seen to be accepted by Duryodhana in the above three verses.

Similarly, Maheshwasa means he who carries the great bow (maharatha), what is meant by the bow is clear when it is referred to the Upanishads –

“Pranavo dhanu: sharohi Atma Brahma tallakshyam uchyate...” (Mundaka Upanishad II.ii.4)

The Sacred Word (AUM) is called the bow, the arrow is the Individual self and Brahman (Absolute) is its target; He shall be pierced by him whose attention does not swerve. Then he will become one with the Absolute like the arrow becomes one with the target whence it has pierced it.

Therefore, Meditation upon AUM (Pranava) is suggested through epithets like these and should not be mixed up as historical aspects of war. The whole Gita is thus a metaphor picturing the subjective war where one fights his own self through reflection, introspection, contemplation and evolves further from a man to a man of perfection represented by Arjuna and Krishna respectively.

Sloka 7:

**asmākaṁ tu viśhiṣṭā ye tānnibodha dwijottama
nāyakā mama sainyasya sanjñārthaṁ tñbravāmi te**

Know also, O best among the twice-born, the names of those who are the most distinguished amongst ourselves, the leaders of my army; these I name to thee for thy information.

Addressing his master as ‘the best among the twice-born’, Duryodhana - the tyrant king had undermined all his mental strength. The more he realized the combined strength of the great personalities arrayed in the opposite camp, the more abjectly nervous he felt. In order to revive himself, like a weak man whistling to himself to escape from his own mental fears, Duryodhana wanted to hear words of encouragement from his teachers and elders. But, Drona - the Acharya chose to remain silent and the helpless king had to

find for himself new means of encouragement to revive his own drooping enthusiasm. Therefore, he started enumerating the great leaders in his own army.

He addresses his own teacher as ‘the best among twice-born’ which is a usual synonym for a Brahmana (whoever works for the good of the world). This is but instinctive fear which is natural with all men of foul motives and crooked dealings. When we are not ourselves pure, we will project our own weaknesses and impurities on others who are working around us as our subordinates.

Like Dhritharashtra in verse 1, Duryodhana is still speaking from the relativist stand point. He insists on talking of “our side” or “my army”. The evils of war as they might affect humanity as a whole are carefully excluded, till Arjuna’s confusion opens the question from a non-relativist point of view. The word *asmakam*, meaning among us or our side, is therefore underlined by the author Vyasa as the first word in this verse. The list of names is not meant to be merely a catalog of warriors to be treated indifferently.

The names are meant to be understood as belonging either to the blast or counter-blast aspects of the situation, which is to be examined as it unravels itself, both as a battle of events and as progressive revaluation of dharma (right conduct) or spiritual values in the chapters that follow. *Samjna* really means more than the name or class. It has an element of further recognition as coming under a distinct category. What Vyasa wants to accomplish here is quite evident. He wants the reader of the Gita to avoid confusing the actual with the spiritual values implied. The literary device in the mind of the author thus comes into evidence quite deliberately at the end of the last line. This is most vital for the reader to see.

Sloka 8:

**bhavānbhīṣmaśhcha karṇaśhcha kṛipaśhcha samitiñjayaḥ
aśhvathāmā vikarṇaśhcha saumadattis tathaiva cha**

You and Bhishma, and Karna, and Kripa, the victor in war, Ashvatthama and Vikarna and also the son of Somadatta

Bhavan: thyself, i.e. Drona, who taught archery

Bhishma: A teacher and patriarch, reputed for his celibacy and high purity of life; much respected by all.

Karna: Born of the Sun-god and Kunti, mother of Pandavas.

Kripa: Brother of Kripa, the wife of Drona, but sympathetic to Pandavas

Ashvatthama: Son of Drona

Vikarna: A ruthless fighter

Saumatatti: Son of Somadatta, king of the Bahikas

In verse 25, Krishna himself makes pointed reference to Drona and Bhishma as against all the rest of the army, not excluding even Kings. It is clear that the issue involves spiritual factors personified by the characters Bhishma and Drona, and that the interests of clashing kings are but incidental to the situation which is gradually being developed. The sound “Bhi” in Bhishma indicates fear and the character Drona is indicating duality and all evil associated with it. It is from duality that fear and delusion arise. The subjective battle of self-unfoldment constitutes fighting against duality and fear. In the epic Sri Krishna steps down as the charioteer and Shikhandi takes his place when Arjuna meets Bhishma face to face in battle. Shikhandi is the symbol of Samnyasa (renunciation), which is surrendering the ego-”I” and the sense of “mine” at the ideal or the altar of worship (material or spiritual). Therefore, if one is to fight fear – the only way is to renounce the ego - “I” and the sense of “Mine” and fight/strive from such a neutral standpoint (which we will see in detail in future chapters).

This systematic thought development finally reaches a focal point with the beginning of the dialogue (samvada) proper (from chapter II, verse 10 onwards). The dialogue constitutes the core of the Gita. In the *Gita-Dhyana*, this teaching is referred to as a “perfume” or gandha of the lotus-flower, to be enjoyed by the good men of the world who seek spiritual values. The historical aspects or episodes contained in the grand epic Mahabharatha are treated as extraneous or gross, being described as the petals and anthers of the lotus.

Mahabharatha is called an Itihasa (epic) since it contains supreme values of life (ithiha), the literal meaning also confirms this

Mahatvath Bharathatvath iti Mahabharata: ||

That which is exalted (Mahatvath), and which is of the nature of supreme light (Bharavathvath) is called Mahabharata.

The perfume of the song of wisdom or the song of dialectics is the supreme value for the good man. That is the fragrance which comes as rhapsody in this song divine – Gita. Looking at this verse, Duryodhana, in his mental hysteria, got slightly upset at the subjective onslaught of his own brutal motives and past crimes, like the true dictator that he was, he regained his balance in no time. The moment he had spilt out in his insulting arrogance, the term ‘twice-born’ in addressing his teacher, he realised that he had overstepped the bounds of discretion. Perhaps the cold silence of the revered Acharya spoke amply to Duryodhana.

Sloka 9:

**anye cha bahavaḥ śhūrā madarthe tyaktajīvitāḥ
nānā-śhastra-praharaṇāḥ sarve yuddha-viśhārādāḥ**

And many other heroes who are willing to die for me, who have various missiles and weapons, and all skilled in warfare.

It should be noted that “willing to die for me” shows the defense of precious values dear to human beings. Fanatics will die for their faith in holy war. Faith becomes at least as precious as life. Duryodhana here represents a life-value connected with kingship and power in this world. This is held precious by his followers. But of course, however exalted such a value might be, it is still in the relativist plane. Their other qualifications are those which are attributes of the workaday world. They carry diverse weapons and are skilled in warfare. Their capability to lay down their lives for the relativist value of kingship (ownership) is therefore the only spiritual factor to their credit.

This epithet “willing to die for me” is therefore to fix one generic character common to all such men of foul values, who are affiliated to a central relativist value personified in this character, Duryodhana, who utters such blasphemous words towards his own teacher. It shows his disintegrated personality or repressed fears. Upanishads shows a man of integral personality, in whom the mind-body complex is in harmonious union (this was also indicated by the battle formations of pandavas and kauravas, in previous verses).

He whose speech is based on mind and contrariwise is one who has an integrated personality. Drona is the teacher of archery for both Duryodhana (Kauravas) and Pandavas. When dialectically restated Drona means he who causes trouble or he who hold rancor/hatred. Duality is the cause of such a character which is already seen in the last verse.

To win over such an aspect in the human personality, one has to see himself in his fellow beings. The Isa Upanishad says:

**yastu sarvāṇi bhūtāni ātmanyevānupaśyati |
sarvabhūteṣu cātmānam tato na vijugupsate || (Isa Upanishad, Verse 6)**

But he who sees everywhere the Self in all existences and all existences in the Self, shrinks not thereafter from aught.

The fact that Karna was born of Sun-god and Kunti was unknown to Pandavas, who at once celebrated his death and also mourned when knowing that he was their brother. Such a metaphorically rich situation is shown to us by Sage Vyasa to make us see the Truth that each

of us are born out of the same womb of creation. When this fact is not known, one stoops to the level of hatred and this results in warfare. This is to be remembered by the reader.

Sloka 10:

**aparyāptaṁ tadasmākaṁ balaṁ bhīṣhmābhirakṣhitam
paryāptaṁ tvidameteṣhāṁ balaṁ bhīmābhirakṣhitam**

This army of ours which is under the care of Bhishma is insufficient but that army of theirs which is under the care of Bhima is adequate.

Duryodhana himself has an inkling of the poverty of this type of spirituality here represented in the Kaurava side, when he feels diffident about the army led by Bhishma. This is the first supreme example of the special style found so often in the Gita. In the first place there is a symmetry to be seen in the construction of the verse. Bhima (the Strong) and Bhishma (the Terrible) are evidently brought in to be treated as counterparts of a situation in the world of actuality from which the subtler dialectics of the later theoretical arguments are to have their natural springboard.

Aparyaptam: has been differently construed by Sridhara and Anandagiri; by Sridhara as meaning “insufficient” and by Anandagiri as “unlimited”. Perhaps an equilibrium of qualitative and quantitative elements is purposely intended by the author here. The usual or first meaning, “insufficient” or “unequal to the task” suits the sense here definitely, especially if we note that as a relativist, as Duryodhana is intended to be here, his diffidence is understandable in the same way as the *nimittani-cha-pashyami* (I see omens) of Arjuna is understandable (in verse 31). Diffidence or strange omens have to be set off one against the other in the revaluation of relativism in absolutist terms which is going to take place as the chapters proceed. Both are forms of doubt - one here and now, and the other with an element of the hereafter added on. Arjuna being a *purva-pakshin* (anterior critic) of the contemplative context, his doubt is superior to that of Duryodhana, because it includes *iha* and *para*, the “here” and the “hereafter”, while Duryodhana’s doubt is confined to the “here” only.

“That army of ours” and “this army of theirs” are again put in a delicate dialectical relationship. “That-ours” and “this-theirs” - to the extent that reciprocity is suggested, to that extent Duryodhana is to be credited a good man. The interchange of “that” for “this” again introduces a special style of the Gita upon which we lay emphasis because it is in keeping with the full subtle interplay of dialectical values for which this is only a preparation. This is by no means a matter of grammatical quibbling. This perfect symmetry can be no accident and must have been consciously, intentionally brought in by the author for reasons we have stated.

Sloka 11:

ayaneṣhu cha sarveṣhu yathā-bhāgamavasthitāḥ

bhīṣhmamevābhirakṣhantu bhavantaḥ sarva eva hi

And let all of you, standing in your respective positions at the entrance to every formation, keep guard even on Bhishma

On the side of the Kauravas this verse makes it clear that the protection of the spirituality personified by Bhishma is their dearest collective value as far as they could understand. That is why he is asked to be protected, although all other (Drona for example) might deserve equal protection. It should be further noticed that this verse shows many plurals employed, numerous ranks and files, numerous divisions, numerous generals. The word *sarva* (all, implying many) occurs twice. This is evidently to emphasize the fact that unitive command is lacking, as contrasted with the other army, as we shall notice presently. Quantitative and numerical factors prevail here. Of course there is Bhishma as a central figure, but he is too old to take any initiative of a unitive pattern. It is he who needs personal protection, rather than himself leading others. As contrasted with the ‘vertical’ or orderly unitive organization of the Pandava army, we find here among the Kauravas a ‘horizontal’ amorphous or mass situation prevailing. The difference suggested here will become evident as we proceed.

Sloka 12:

**tasya sañjanayan harṣhaṁ kuru-vṛiddhaḥ pitāmahaḥ
sīmha-nādaṁ vinadyochchaiḥ śhaṅkhaṁ dadhmau pratāpavān**

So as to cheer him, the mighty old kuru patriarch roared loudly like a lion and blew his conch

To generate joy (in Duryodhana). The lack of self-confidence in Duryodhana becomes explicit. Duryodhana’s intuition of defeat here are meant to be banished by the blowing of the conch-shell by Bhishma. As seen earlier, Duryodhana commands everyone to protect Bhishma (fear) and in return Bhishma blew his conch as to frighten his commanders opponents.

Sloka 13:

**tataḥ śhaṅkhāśhcha bheryaśhcha paṇavānaka-gomukhāḥ
sahasaivābhyahanyanta sa śhabdastumulo ’bhavat**

Then conches and drums and gongs, (other) drums, horns, were played together suddenly, and that sound made a confused clang.

Note here the variety of instruments which are sounded together, and that the sound was a *tumula* which implies “excited, confused sound” - a chaotic condition. This is a natural

prerequisite for the orderly unitive teaching of Brahmavidya (Science of the Absolute) which is to follow.

Sloka 14:

**tataḥ śhvetairhayairyukte mahati syandane sthitau
mādhavaḥ pāṇḍavaśhchaiva divyau śhaṅkhau pradadhmatuḥ**

Then (both) standing in their great chariot, to which white horses were yoked, Madhava (Krishna) and the son of Pandu (Arjuna) blew (the two together) their divine conches.

Here we must notice the magic circle round the two personalities of Krishna and Arjuna, as if they were having equal status in the context of something superior to merely human values. Both their conches have the coupling epithet *divyau sankhau* (a pair of divine conches). Further, they are in the same chariot, the charioteer as we know turns out to be the teacher of Brahmavidya (the Science of the Absolute). The white horses are also symbolic of their divine or pure (sattvik) character. This picture indicates the presence of discipline and unity which are the prerequisites for victory.

Sloka 15:

**pāñchajanyaṁ hṛīṣhīkeśho devadattaṁ dhanañjayah
pauṇḍraṁ dadhmau mahā-śhaṅkhaṁ bhīma-karmā vṛikodarah**

Hrishikesa (Krishna) blew Panchajanya, and Arjuna blew Devadatta. He of wolf-like appetite and deeds of enormity (Bhima) blew his great conch, Paundra

It is to be noted that the Pandavas started with the Lord blowing his conch, which indicates that there is a higher degree of Surrender towards the ideal and uniformity. Hrishikesha in sanskrit means lord of the senses. Naming his conch Panchajanya has some details behind it. An asura by the name of panchajana once hid himself in the ocean fearing the Lord. He was found and killed by the lord and his conch was released and it was then used for the purpose of imparting Dharma.

We will find many instances like these in puranas which will confuse the reader if taken literally. Here, the killing is done using the Lord's weapon known as Sudarshana, which is nothing but a new perspective (sushtum-darshana). This is not only seen in Puranas, if we take the life of any great man of achievement, we will see that his personality have been changed once and for all by knowledge, at some point in his life. We must not blindly follow such men and try to imitate them, but realize this great potential within us and invoke it.

Sloka 16:

**anantavijayaṁ rājā kuntī-putro yudhiṣṭhiraḥ
nakulaḥ sahadevaścha sughoṣha-manipuṣhpakau**

Prince Yudhishtira, son of Kunti, blew Anantavijaya and Nakula and Sahadeva blew (together) the Sughosa and Manipushpaka.

The name *Anantavijaya* (endless victory) is an apt name for the conch of Yudhishtira, in view of what prince's name itself means, "firm in battle". Both steadiness and endless victory may be said to go together. Notice here that in a proper order of precedence King Yudhishtira should have blown his conch before Arjuna and Krishna, he is given a secondary place suggests aesthetic values. Virtue and aesthetics do not count so much as the divine absolutism represented by Krishna and Arjuna.

Yudhishtira is addressed as Kaunteya (Son of Kunti) and is given equal status with Nakula and Sahadeva who are twins born to Madri and Aswini kumaras (Earth). The study is not complete if we avoid the significance of Kunti, who represents tolerance, patience and knowledge. She raised Nakula and Sahadeva just like her three sons Yudhishtira, Bhima and Arjuna and called them Pancha-Pandavas (Five Pandavas) which is the epitome of motherhood. She had to face cruel challenges throughout her life when her enemies tried to kill the Pancha Pandavas in different ways, even then she is found to say to Krishna:

"Vipatho naiva Vipatha: Sambatho naiva Sambatha:"

I don't see trouble as misfortunes, neither do I see, fortunes as wealth.

This indicates her courage, patience, tolerance and wisdom - which is the summum bonum of true motherhood.

Sloka 17-18:

**kāśhyaścha parameśhvāsaḥ śhikhaṇḍī cha mahā-rathaḥ
dhṛiṣṭadyumno virāṭaścha sātyakiś cha parājitaḥ
drupado draupadeyaścha sarvaśchaḥ pṛithivī-pate
saubhadraścha mahā-bāhuḥ śhaṅkhāndadhmuḥ pṛithak pṛithak**

And the King of Kasi, excellent bowman; Sikhadin, great charioteer, Dhrishtadyumna and Virata and the unconquered Satyaki;

Drupada and the sons of Druapadi, O Lord of the Earth, and the son of Subhadra of mighty arms, from all sides blew his conch seperately

On the Kaurava side only one man, Bhishma, blew a conch-shell of any unique nature. The rest was a hullabaloo of clanging instruments. On the Pandava side, the clarion calls of the conches come in clear graded succession, in which a scale of values can be discerned.

Sanjaya addresses Dritharashtra as “Lord of the Earth”, which is ironic in a sense since Dritharashtra held no good qualities essential for a King. He was the “holder of the kingdom”, who could not lift his vision from “I-ness” and “Mine-ness”. Sanjaya gives a hint that the opposition was those who were unconquered which was a subtle warning to the blind old king.

The mighty armed Subhadrathmajan (Abhimanyu) when subjected to critique during his death is highlighted here. Abhimanyu indicates pride in the side of the Pandava, the sad fate he faces during battle is due to the fact that he in his pride engaged in warfare without proper knowledge of how to retire (nivriti) from such a situation when he was faced with challenges bigger than him. This is how most of us gets trapped in the battleground of life or the field of action - without proper understanding of how to engage and retire from an action.

Sloka: 19

**sa ghoṣho dhārtarāṣṭrāṇāṃ hṛidayāni vyadārayat
nabhaśhcha pṛithivīm chaiva tumulo nunādayan**

That loud blast, filling the earth and sky with sound, pierced the hearts of Dritharashtra's sons.

This blast from the Pandava side “pierced the hearts of the Kauravas”. It touched “earth and sky”, i.e. included all possible hierophantic values as against the mere earthly confusion of the conch-blasts of the Kauravas. In what sense were the hearts of the Kauravas bitten-through to the extent that they lost confidence in all the mundane things they held dear? New values involving both esoteric as well as exoteric seem to be implicit in the message of the blast of the Pandavas.

Sloka: 20-21

**atha vyavasthitān dṛiṣṭvā dhārtarāṣṭrān kapi-dhwajāḥ
pravṛitte śhastra-sampāte dhanurudyamya pāṇḍavaḥ**

**hṛiṣhīkeśhaṃ tadā vākyam idam āha mahī-pate
senayor ubhayor madhye rathaṃ sthāpaya me 'chyuta**

Then, beholding the sons of Dritharashtra standing marshalled in order; while the flight of arrows (was) beginning, the son of Pandu (Arjuna) of monkey-ensign, took up his bow

And O King, (said Sanjaya), he (Arjuna) spoke thus to Hrishikesha (Krishna): O Achyuta! Stop my chariot right in the middle between the two armies.

It is most important to note the content of the last line of verse 20, which says that the shower of arrows was starting and Arjuna had already taken up his bow. Upto this point it is clear that as a warrior he is not suffering from any weak-heartedness or doubt. The second line of verse 21: “Stop my chariot, O Achyuta, between the two armies,” does not suggest anything cowardice either. Arjuna is prepared to risk going into no man’s land between the two armies, of which everyone who knows warfare ancient or modern can understand the danger.

Arjuna is pictured here as having monkey (*kapi*) as his ensign. Vyasa wants to indicate his mental state through this, monkeys are always restless, which is the condition of every mind (*manas*). Therefore, the goal of the picture of Arjuna in chariot having monkey-ensign is his journey from his weakness and confusion to a steadiness in thought and a unitive attitude of being a yogi. This picture is inspired from the Kathopanishad which uses a chariot as an illustration of the human personality.

||1.3.3||. *Know the Atman as the Lord of the chariot, the body as the chariot; know the intellect as the charioteer and the mind again as the reins.*

||1.3.4||. *They say, the senses are the horses and their objects are the roads; the Atman, the senses and the mind united, the wise call the enjoyer.*

How this is significant to the Mahabharata war is explained further,

||1.3.5||. *He who has no discrimination and whose mind is always uncontrolled, his senses are not controllable like vicious horses of a driver.*

This is the case of Duryodhana and all who represents the Kaurava forces, where their minds are uncontrolled due to the surging up of desires and thus blind to righteousness or any such values of life. This illustration is not to be used to judge others, but only for introspection. Only he who does this can fight against his own wrong motives and values and achieve a more nobler life. How? By depending on his discrimination (*buddhi*) which is the steady mind. This is said in the Katha Upanishad in the following verses.

||1.3.6||. *But he who has understanding and whose mind is always controlled, his senses are under control like good horses of a driver.*

||1.3.7||. *But he, who has no discrimination, and whose mind is not under control, and who is always impure, does not reach the goal, but enters into the round of births and deaths.*

||1.3.8||. *But he who has understanding, who has his mind always under control, and who is pure, reaches that goal whence he is not born again.*

Therefore, Vyasa is picturing a subjective warfare and when Arjuna asks Krishna to ride his chariot into the no-man's land, it is the individual realizing the need for introspection and self-study. The total subjective unfoldment begins when one watches himself and his mind.

Sloka 22-23:

**yāvadetān nirīkṣhe 'haṁ yoddhu-kāmān avasthitān
kairmayā saha yoddhavyam asmin raṇa-samudyame**

**yotsyamānān avekṣhe 'haṁ ya ete 'tra samāgatāḥ
dhārtarāṣṭhṛasya durbuddher yuddhe priya-chikīrṣhavaḥ**

So that I may behold these standing eager to fight by my side in the present battle-undertaking;

And might observe these here gathered together who desire to please in war the evil-minded son of Dritharashtra

These verses are meant to be taken together. This is significant. For the first time the two sides of the army tend to be thought of together - not in the usual way of looking only at the enemy. To an ordinary fighter his enemies have prime importance. Arjuna, being already spiritually inclined, says here definitely that he wants to go to the middle of the two armies, equidistant from either of them, so that he could see not only the army that he is to fight with, but also the army he is to fight against from a unitive view from a central, neutral position.

It is already mentioned about the kind of war vyasa is trying to portray through Arjuna or a contemplative student who is ready for introspection. He will have to take a neutral position when he is to study his mind, without having likes or dislikes for any kind of perceptions, feelings or thoughts.

The two verses together which read so redundantly, have only one purpose, which is to stress the difference between Duryodhana's one-sided attitude of diffidence in verse 10 as against Arjuna's own in which both parties are equally involved. This altogether changes the complexion of Arjuna's state of confusion, because he begins to view the problem from a more unitive or humanistic standpoint. This picture is very helpful for a student who is trying to control his senses through the mind, because it is impossible to introspect having likes and dislikes as a constant disturbance.

Sloka 24-25:

**sañjaya uvācha:
evam ukto hṛīṣhīkeśho guḍākeśhena bhārata
senayor ubhayor madhye sthāpayitvā rathottamam**

bhīṣhma-droṇa-pramukhataḥ sarveṣhām cha mahī-kṣhitām

uvācha pārtha paśhyaitān samavetān kurūn iti

Sanjaya Said:

Thus addressed by Gudakesa (Arjuna), Hrishikesha (Krishna), O Bharatha (Dritharashtra), having stationed that excellent chariot right in the middle between the two armies

Facing Bhishma and Drona and all the rulers of the earth, (Krishna) said: O Partha (Arjuna)! Behold these Kurus gathered (here).

Sanjaya said: Krishna took the chariot on Arjuna's request and held them equidistant between two armies, facing Bhishma and Drona and said "Behold these Kurus gathered here". We should note how Krishna is careful not to influence Arjuna's mind in any other way than what would be most normal. He would not want Arjuna to look on both sides, because he knows that might confuse him, and carefully places Arjuna facing Bhishma and Drona of the opposing armies only and, what is more explicit, he says "behold these Kurus" and not "both these armies." Sanjaya gives this picture to King Dritharashtra and addresses him as 'O Bharatha', the word Bharatha means he who revels in knowledge, the irony is intended by Sanjaya here. Arjuna on the other hand is called Gudakesha which means he who have woken up from sleep, this indicates the peculiar character of his confusion (of spiritual type) which differentiates him from Duryodhana.

Krishna takes him face to face with whom he must fight against i.e. Bhisma (Fear) and Drona (intolerance). He points them and calls them Kurus, which when dialectically restated becomes the field of action. A human personality is greatly disturbed by his own subjective fears as well as what he sees as challenges outside, and Krishna says we must fight against these two.

Sloka 26-27:

**tatrāpaśhyat sthitān pārthaḥ pitṛīn atha pitāmahān
āchāryān mātulān bhrātṛīn putrān pautrān sakhīms tathā**

**śhvaśhurān suhṛidaśh chaiva senayor ubhayor api
tān samīkṣhya sa kaunteyaḥ sarvān bandhūn avasthitān**

Then Partha (Arjuna) saw standing, fathers as well as grandfathers, teachers, maternal uncles, brothers, sons, grandsons, and companions too

And the son of Kunti (Arjuna), also seeing these relatives, fathers-in-law and friends, all standing, in both armies

Arjuna begins by seeing on the enemy's side many of his own kith and kin, besides teachers. Even though it is mentioned that he sees his fathers, neither Indra or Pandu is present in Kurukshetra, same for grandsires, teachers, grandfathers, sons and grandsons. Therefore,

Arjuna is beginning to see his past, present and future with regard to the war and its evil effects. This kind of an absolutist vision makes him weak and incapable of fighting against kauravas even though they are his enemies. Sri Krishna points towards them and says “Behold these Kurus”, which is indicating that war is necessary towards those who put us in danger.

The confusion worsens, because he finds kith and kin not only in the opposite army, but on both sides. Confusion thus becomes more confounded, thus starting the real trouble with which the rest of Gita is concerned. The reference in this verse to his friends or relations in both the armies is important for the right appraisal of the delicate dialectics to follow. This is the circumstance that finally succeeds in overwhelming this battle veteran and hero.

Sloka 28,29,30:

**kṛipayā parayāviṣṭo viṣhīdann idam abravīt
dṛiṣṭvemaṁ sva-janaṁ kṛiṣṇa yuyutsuṁ samupasthitam**

**sīdanti mama gātrāṇi mukhaṁ cha pariśuṣhyati
vepathuś cha śharīre me roma-harṣhaś cha jāyate**

**gāṇḍīvaṁ sraṁsate hastāt tvak chaiva paridahyate
na cha śhaknomy avasthātuṁ bhramatīva cha me manaḥ**

Filled by a supreme pity, in mental distress (Arjuna) said: Beholding my own people, O Krishna, standing together, wanting to fight,

My limbs fail and mouth dries up, my body trembles and my hair stands on end;

(the bow) Gandiva slips from my hand, and my skin feels as if burning all over, and I am unable to stand and my mind is whirling round as it were;

The nature of Arjuna’s state of mind is described by the first words *kripaya paraya*, usually translated as “great pity” or “melted with pity”. Such translations are inadequate to bring out that special state of mind intended here. *Paraya* definitely means of transcendental or supreme order. What kind of pity is this which is here qualified as supreme? It is supreme to the extent that it envisages both sides involved in the conflict with at least the first degree of dispassionate equality. But a residual conflict still seems to persist in Arjuna’s mind - in the second line where there is a reference to *svajanam* (my own people). This shows he is still a relativist and not a thoroughgoing absolutist in his ways of thinking. The duality of “my own people” versus “strangers” remains. Hence the characteristic *vishada* or “dejection” of this chapter, and his war is against this inner vision of multiplicity not an external war.

The list of symptoms enumerated here are not those exactly known to normal psychology or pathology. Among them is one very intriguingly described as *romaharshas* (hair standing on end). It is an expression familiar in India. It marks a state of exaltation or ecstasy when a

sentiment thrills the body-mind. It is not always due to fear as has been held. The kinship of the other symptoms covered in these verses to the state of mind of Sri Rama in the first chapters of *Yoga Vasistha* might help us in forming a correct idea about its true character. It really belongs to the mystical rather than the merely pathological or psychological order. The bow slips from his hand and this, taken with his giddiness, shows general lassitude, or a lack of zest or interest in life in general rather than any fear. Lack of zest leads to a second stage marked in 1,47 where he makes up his mind to throw away his bow with its arrow.

Sloka 31:

**nimittāni cha paśhyāmi viparītāni keśhava
na cha śhreyo 'nupaśhyāmi hatvā sva-janam āhave**

And I see conflicting portents, O Kesava (Krishna), nor do I foresee good from killing one's own people in battle.

Oh Kesava (Krishna) I see bad omens and don't see any good in killing my kith and kin in battle. There is no victory for Arjuna against his inner conflicts until he gives up the idea of I and Mine (my people). The second line mentions spiritual factors proper, when the conflict is conceived in the form of a doubt, thus emerging from mere feelings into the domain of morals. Arjuna sees no moral or spiritual merit in killing kinsmen. Thus he is capable of formulating an opinion, although confused. His is therefore no ordinary confusion, fear or sadness.

Sloka 32:

**na kāṅkṣhe vijayaṁ kṛiṣhṇa na cha rājyaṁ sukhāni cha
kiṁ no rājyena govinda kiṁ bhogair jīvitena vā**

I do not wish for victory, O Krishna, nor kingdom nor pleasures; what is kingdom to us, O Govinda (Krishna), what enjoyment, or even life!

Oh Krishna, I do not desire victory, kingdom or pleasures got by killing my kinsmen. What is the use for such victory? All these are indicating a state of dispassion in Arjuna which are signs that he is turning towards the absolutist wisdom teachings of Krishna. Arjuna's stand is further finalized here. He has what is known as vairagya or detachment from the usual attractions or lures of life.

This Vairagya is not different in essence from what is required of a *brahmachari* as a seeker of wisdom who is to have discrimination between eternal and non-eternal. There is no confusion here. It conforms to what is traditionally laid down as a prerequisite for spiritual life even of a Vedantin. Relinquishment (Tyaga) and detachment (vairagya) have always been considered essential for the wisdom seeker. Arjuna here is like a wise man or correct absolutist. Arjuna's

superiority here to a mere coward, as evident in this verse, has to be kept in mind to avoid mistaking the true nature of his conflict.

Sloka 33,34:

**yeṣhām arthe kāṅkṣitaṁ no rājyaṁ bhogāḥ sukhāni cha
ta ime 'vasthitā yuddhe prāṇāṁs tyaktvā dhanāni cha
āchāryāḥ pitaraḥ putrās tathaiva cha pitāmahāḥ
mātulāḥ śhvaśhurāḥ pautrāḥ śhyālāḥ sambandhinas tathā**

They for whose sake kingdoms, enjoyments and pleasures are desired by us, are standing here in battle, having renounced their interests in life and wealth.

Teachers, fathers, sons and grandfathers; maternal uncles, fathers-in-law, grandsons, brothers-in-law as well as (other) kinsmen.

Here Arjuna suddenly relapses into a partially relativist standpoint. The inconsistency of wavering alternation between outright absolutism and a confused form of relativism, even though the latter is not without a touch of humanity implying contemplation. The character of the confusion, which is legitimately Vedantic in its nature, becomes fully evident only in chapter II, 8. In the light of the definitive verse, all the preceding verses must be understood. The transition from a Puranic (i.e. legend of a sacred character) to a Vedantic (i.e. philosophical) context takes place between these two chapters. The *acharya* (teachers) mentioned here in verse 34 evidently refers to Drona, Kripa and others if any. The last word in the first line, *pitamahāḥ* (grandfathers) must apply primarily to Bhishma. To whom we desired prosperity and grandeur, they are arrayed in front of us ready to give up all and even their life. It is important to note that we are passing through a transition of Arjuna from being a dynamic man of action to being a contemplative as Krishna's disciple. Each of these verses must be carefully studied so that each question Arjuna asks will reflect on the readers mind and their answers are available in vivid form in the chapters that follow. This reflection will save any man from all the fears that lurk in his inner life. Sage-bard Veda Vyasa presents through Arjuna the vital question of how to attain success from our inner fears and anxieties.

The war against the Kauravas is the internal conflict of man against his own lower or baser nature, the transformation from "me" to "Ideal-me". This can only be successful when one grows bigger than his self-limiting habits, desires, fear and anxieties. When once he becomes aware of his inner enemies, his intellect with its convictions starts guiding him gradually to success. Psychologists attribute three personality traits for every man (Parent, Adult, Child). When one learns to self-adjust to any of these according to the demand of situation, then we can avoid any kind of mutual disagreement or in other words, the situation becomes conducive for proper behavior. This is what Vyasa indicates through the terms *Acharya*, *pitara*, *putrah* (Teachers, fathers, sons).

Thus, the three traits of personality and their mechanism is dissected and is clearly shown to us through the Kauravas when they are arrayed in battle. Greed, jealousy, hatred and all similar qualities are indicated through the Kaurava forces and Krishna points at them and tells Arjuna to identify them as his own enemies. This is the inner battle when man fights against his own baser-self and makes his way to the ideal-self. The inner conflict of Arjuna is the same fate of anyone who identifies his limitations and begins his fight and makes his way to his own ideal-self. This is possible only when man completes his transformation from the relativistic to the absolute, in his or her life.

Sloka 35:

**etān na hantum ichchhāmi ghnato 'pi madhusūdana
api trailokya-rājyasya hetoḥ kiṁ nu mahī-kṛite**

These I do not want to kill, though (they kill me), O Madhusudhana (Krishna), not even for the sake of dominion over the three worlds - how then for the sake of earth?

Arjuna is hesitant to fight only because he considers death to be more noble than killing his own kith and kin. A man is unable to make his transformation from the self to the ideal-self only when he considers the lower qualities as his own and therefore is unable to identify them as his enemies. No success is ever possible to such a man. The three worlds mentioned are indicating the three states of consciousness (Waking, Dream and Deep Sleep), without renouncing the “I” and “Mine”, arjuna cannot make his way to the transcendental which is the transformation from relativistic to the absolute.

Sloka 36:

**nihatya dhārtarāṣṭrān naḥ kā prītiḥ syāj janārdana
pāpam evāśhrayed asmān hatvaitān ātatāyinaḥ**

Having killed the sons of Dritharashtra, what delight can there be for us, O Janardhana (Krishna)? Only sin would come to us after killing this marauding rabble.

The word *atatayinah* does not merely mean desperadoes. It means greedy opportunists, persons infatuated with wrong or exaggerated notions of worldly values who readily resort to premature aggression. If the meaning of the word is to be further clarified it can only be done by taking Arjuna's attitude of not wanting pleasure at all as its opposite or counterpart. Some people are easily greedy. They grab and take advantage of a situation. Others give in too much. Both of these miss the neutral middle way, which is that of the complete absolutist to be understood, as we shall see, from the Gita. At any rate the author, by this word *atatayinah* wants to indicate that the army of Kauravas is not motivated by any higher moral or spiritual considerations than just greed or attachment.

From a subjective standpoint it is our hesitation to fight against the baser-self that is indicated by the attitude of Arjuna here, even though the Kauravas (baser qualities) is deserving to be sublimated.

Sloka 37:

**tasman nārha vayan hantum dhārtarāṣṭrān sa-bāndhavān
sva-janaṁ hi kathaṁ hatvā sukhinaḥ syāma mādava**

And so we ought not to kill the sons of Dhritarashtra our relations; for how, indeed, can we be happy after killing our own people, O Madhava (Krishna)?

Therefore, Arjuna stood his ground that killing his own kith and kin will only bring sin and not happiness. This doubt related to Arjuna can be observed in everyone till they find out the true absolute nature. Sin in Hinduism is not the action itself, but it is the wrong identification with the body and considering the body as the Self. The true nature of everyone is actionless, since the Self is all-pervading. Once we identify with the body and consider it as the Self, doubts are unavoidable. All wrong actions and qualities in life comes from the wrong identification with the body as the Self, to win over this mis-conception is the whole spiritual path and patience is the key to it.

Sloka 38,39:

**yady apy ete na paśhyanti lobhopahata-chetasah
kula-kṣhaya-kṛitaṁ doṣhaṁ mitra-drohe cha pātakam**

**kathaṁ na jñeyam asmābhiḥ pāpād asmān nivartitum
kula-kṣhaya-kṛitaṁ doṣhaṁ prapaśhyadbhir janārdana**

Even if they whose minds are overpowered by greed see no wrong in the destruction of family (and) no crime in treachery to friends,

Yet why should we not learn to turn away from this sin, we who do see wrong in the destruction of family, O Janardhana (Krishna)

Here we come to considerations of wisdom or intelligence. Arjuna says in effect, “Why should we not be wise as against the foolishness of our relations?” Though Arjuna bases his argument on wisdom, it still lacks the balanced or neutral way of absolutism, leaving it still vitiated by relativist considerations, At the end of verse 39 we find Arjuna still concerned about the destruction of *Kula* (Clan).

Indian philosophy teaches about five kinds of purity, viz purity of mind, action, clan, body and speech. Reflection is what makes the mind pure, to maintain a cultured value based thoughts is thus purity of mind. Not to harm others with our actions is purity of action, to maintain a behavior that is loyal to one's clan and its values is purity of clan. To give peace through speech is purity

of speech and the purity of body is self-explanatory. If one is not following these there becomes destruction of one's family and its traditions which is being indicated by Arjuna's words here. These relativistic values are based on one Absolute value which is called Brahman in Vedantic terminology. It is the indestructible truth behind creation and dissolution. The author wants to make it clear that once a man starts his quest towards this spiritual truth he will at once purify his family. This absolutist approach is still lacking in Arjuna's way of escapist attitude. To renounce one's obligatory duties is not to reach a spiritual plane, it is by consistent enquiry while engaging in one's duties towards his family and society that he raises himself to that state of absolute perfection.

Sloka 40:

**kula-kṣhaye praṇaśhyanti kula-dharmāḥ sanātanaḥ
dharme naṣṭe kulaṁ kṛtsnam adharmo 'bhibhavaty uta**

In the destruction of family, the immemorial clan traditions perish, and on the loss of tradition the whole clan comes under the sway of lawlessness.

Arjuna here develops his own version of the evils of war - not in terms of humanity as a whole, but in terms of a closed or chosen group of people whose future is dear to him. It is easy to concede that killing out of some important men in a family would lead to disruption of their normal life - not only in a biological sense but as representing a particular cultural growth including certain spiritual values which belong to that clan. No one can deny here again that Arjuna is right in what he says. His only fault could be that he does not conform to the highest standards of the absolutist way of life.

Sloka 41:

**adharmābhibhavāt kṛṣṇa praduṣhyanti kula-striyaḥ
strīṣhu duṣṭāsu vārṣṇeya jāyate varṇa-saṅkaraḥ**

When wrong (ways) prevails, O Krishna, the women of the family become corrupt and when women become corrupt, O Varshneya (Krishna), mixing of clan arises.

The term Varshneya (Vrishni - clan of Krishna) which Arjuna used to address Krishna becomes relevant here, his inner conflict becomes more vivid when he tries to subtly pursue Krishna into believing his own version of the evils of war. Whoever wins the war will kill or imprison the men of that country and the women will be forced to have sexual intercourse thereby having a mixing up of clans and caste.

Sloka 42:

saṅkaro narakāyaiva kula-ghnānām kulasya cha
patanti pitaro hy eṣhām lupta-piṇḍodaka-kriyāḥ

